nature of the first rebellion was religious at first but things changed slowly. The rebellion attracted lots of peasants who were in opposition to the Confucian policies set by the emperor. The government did not possess the power to suppress these rebellions and experienced a major insurgence. General Cao Cao and General Yuan Shao fought against the government and then turned on each other as they both attempted to seize the emperor's seat. Although Cao Cao won the battle, he lost to the southern warlords at the famous Battle of Red Cliffs in 208 CE. This battle is known to be one of the largest naval battles in history. The empire was divided once more into three kingdoms: Shu, Wei and Wu.

The period that followed would be known as the Three Kingdoms era. Although the Shu, Wei and Wu kingdoms were the main players, several other dynasties emerged briefly. These include the Jin and the Wei Dynasties that existed between 208 and 618 CE. It was the Sui Dynasty (589 – 618 CE) that reunited the country once more. The Sui Dynasty is known for using effective government strategies that did not upset the peasants unlike many of the previous rulers.

During the reigns of Emperors Wen and Yang, China saw sections of the Great Wall repaired and lengthened. The Grand Canal was expanded such that it became the longest artificial river in the world. The army enlisted new soldiers to such an extent that the Chinese army became the largest the world had ever seen. Poetry and literature advanced to new levels and many works were published. The tale of Hua Mulan is believed to have originated during this time. In the story, a young woman secretly takes her father's position within the army and creates mischievous havoc. The story is very famous and is told to young children even up until today.

Despite these achievements, both of the emperors looked towards Korea for extra land and resources. Emperor Wen was so obsessed with warfare that he had drained the national treasury to build fortifications and to fund his military campaigns. By the time Emperor Wen's came to an end, the people were fed up with government spending. When Emperor Yang tried to use the people's wealth to fund military campaigns against Korea in a similar fashion, he was assassinated in a coup orchestrated by Yuwen Huaji in 618